

**menler**

*Your turning point in the AI era.*

# Claude Design

*The Compact Playbook*

## SECTION 01

# What Claude Design is

Claude Design is a tool from Anthropic Labs where you build visual work — prototypes, slides, landing pages, dashboards, mockups, one-pagers — by chatting with Claude instead of dragging shapes around in a design tool. You describe what you want, Claude builds a first version on a canvas, and you refine it through conversation.

It's available in research preview on Claude Pro, Max, Team, and Enterprise plans. Enterprise admins need to turn it on (it's off by default).

## What it's good for

- Going from an idea to something visual in minutes — without opening Figma first
- Generating multiple design directions when you'd normally pick just one
- Turning static mockups into clickable, testable prototypes
- Creating pitch decks, one-pagers, and marketing visuals that match your brand
- Drafting wireframes that can hand off straight to engineering

## What it's not (yet)

- **A replacement for Figma or Adobe** for production design work
- **A full multiplayer collaboration tool** sharing works, but real-time co-editing is basic
- **A creative illustration tool** it's structured visual work (UI, decks, layouts), not freeform art

SECTION 02

The interface, in 30 seconds

Claude Design has two main panels:

- **Chat (left side)** where you talk to Claude. Describe what you want, ask for changes, request feedback. This is also where you upload reference images, screenshots, or documents.
- **Canvas (right side)** where the design appears. You can click on any element directly to leave an inline comment, or edit text in place. The Export button sits in the upper right of the canvas.

Quick orientation

| ACTION                  | HOW TO DO IT                                                                          |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Start a new project     | New Project button → describe what you want to build                                  |
| Add reference material  | Drop images, decks, or docs into the chat. Or link a code repo from project settings. |
| Edit a specific element | Click directly on it in the canvas → leave an inline comment                          |
| Edit text in place      | Click into the text on the canvas and type                                            |
| Make broad changes      | Use the chat panel on the left                                                        |
| Save current version    | Tell Claude in chat: “Save what we have and try a different direction”                |
| Export your work        | Export button (top right of canvas) → pick format                                     |
| Share with team         | Share button → choose view, comment, or edit access for org members                   |

## SECTION 03

# The 5-step flow

Every project follows the same rhythm. Once you've done it once, the rest is just variation.

## Step 1

## Create a project and add context

Hit New Project. Before writing your first prompt, give Claude something to work from:

- Screenshots of references you like (competitor sites, inspiration, existing screens)
- An existing slide deck if you want to match its style
- A link to your code repository if you're prototyping something that should match your real product
- A web-captured element from your live site (use the web capture tool for this)
- If your team has a design system set up, your brand colors, fonts, and components are already applied — no upload needed.

## Step 2

## Describe what you want

Write your first prompt in the chat panel. Include four things:

- Goal — what you're building
- Layout — how things should be arranged
- Content — what information shows up
- Audience — who's going to use it

## TIP

*Don't worry about being perfect. Claude will ask clarifying questions if it needs to. See Section 4 for prompt formulas.*

## Step 3

## Review what appears on the canvas

Claude generates a working version on the canvas (right side). Look at it before reacting:

- Does the overall structure match what you imagined?
- Is the brand applied correctly?
- Are you missing anything important?
- What feels off — and is the fix structural (chat) or local (inline comment)?

## Step 4

## Iterate

This is where the real work happens. You have two ways to make changes:

- Inline comments — for targeted edits. Click directly on a button, section, or element and request a change. Best for "make this bigger," "change this color," "swap this for a dropdown."

- Chat — for broad changes. Best for “add a settings panel,” “show me 3 alternative layouts,” “make the whole thing more minimal.”
- Rule of thumb: if you can point at it, comment. If you'd need a paragraph to explain, chat.

Step 5

## Export or share

When you're happy with the result, hit Export (top right of the canvas). Or use the Share button to invite teammates. Export options covered in Section 7. Share options covered in Section 8.

## SECTION 04

## How to write prompts that work

Most disappointing results come from vague prompts. Claude needs to know what you're building, who it's for, and what matters most. Use this formula:

### PROMPT FORMULA

[GOAL] for [AUDIENCE], with [KEY ELEMENTS], in a [STYLE/TONE] feel.

### Weak vs strong prompts

**Weak:** *"Make me a landing page."*

**Strong:** "Landing page for a meditation app aimed at first-time users, with a hero section, 3 feature cards, a testimonial row, and a single CTA to download the app. Calming and minimal — lots of whitespace, soft colors."

**Weak:** *"Design a dashboard."*

**Strong:** "Internal dashboard for ops managers tracking support tickets. Top row: 4 KPI tiles (open, in-progress, resolved today, avg response time). Middle: line chart of tickets over the last 30 days. Bottom: a table of recent tickets with status, owner, and priority."

**Weak:** *"Build a pitch deck."*

**Strong:** "10-slide pitch deck for a Series A SaaS startup in the customer-success space. Slides: cover, problem, solution, market size, product (3 slides), traction, team, ask. Modern, restrained, lots of breathing room. Use one big stat per slide where possible."

### Things to mention if they apply

- **Device targets:** mobile, tablet, desktop, or all three
- **Tone:** minimal, playful, technical, premium, friendly, corporate
- **Existing components:** "use the Primary Button component" or "apply the Card pattern"
- **Accessibility:** mention if WCAG AA contrast or specific accessibility needs matter
- **Number of variations:** "show me 3 different directions" beats getting one you don't like

## SECTION 05

## Iterating: chat vs inline comments

### Use inline comments for...

- Changing a single element's style (color, padding, font size)
- Swapping one control for another (radio buttons → dropdown)
- Adjusting spacing or alignment of a specific section
- Making a component collapsible, expandable, or removable
- Fixing one specific bit of copy

**TIP**

Example: Click on a button, comment: "Use the primary brand color and add 4px more padding on the sides."

### Use chat for...

- Adding or removing entire sections
- Changing the overall layout structure
- Aesthetic shifts ("make it darker," "more minimal," "more playful")
- Requesting 2–3 alternative versions to compare
- Asking Claude to explain choices, audit accessibility, or suggest improvements
- Resetting direction completely

**TIP**

Example: Chat: "Show me 3 alternative layouts for the dashboard — one with metrics in a vertical sidebar, one with metrics on top, one with metrics inline with the chart."

### The feedback that gets the best changes

Specific beats vague every time. "Doesn't look right" gives Claude nothing to act on. "Tighten the spacing between form fields to about 8px" gives it exactly what it needs.

**Vague:** "This feels off."

**Specific:** "The hero text feels too small compared to the CTA button. Make the headline about 1.5x bigger and increase line-height slightly."

### Claude as your design collaborator

Don't just use Claude to generate. Ask it questions too:

"Review this design for accessibility issues."

"Is the visual hierarchy clear here? What would you change?"

"Check the color contrast against WCAG AA."

"Why did you put the CTA in the top right? What are the alternatives?"

*"What's missing from this layout that users would expect?"*

## SECTION 06

## Design system, versions, and exploring

### Your design system, automatically applied

If your team has set up a design system in Claude Design (your design lead does this once), every new project starts with your brand colors, fonts, and components already in place. You don't upload assets each time. Mention specific components by name when prompting ("use the Card component") and Claude will use them.

Teams can maintain more than one design system if you have multiple brands or product surfaces.

### Saving versions and exploring alternatives

Claude saves your iterations automatically, but if you want to explore a completely different direction without losing your current work, just say:

**SAY THIS TO SAVE AND BRANCH**

"Save what we have and try a completely different approach."

Claude will save your current state and start fresh. You can ask it to bring back earlier versions any time during the conversation.

### Asking for variations up front

Often faster than iterating from one starting point. Try:

*"Show me 3 different directions for this landing page — one playful, one corporate, one minimal."*

*"Generate two alternative dashboard layouts so I can compare."*

*"What's the opposite of the current design? Try that."*

SECTION 07

Exporting your work

When your design is ready, hit Export in the upper right of the canvas. Different formats fit different jobs.

| FORMAT                 | WHEN TO USE IT                                                                                          |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PDF                    | Stakeholder reviews, sharing static decks or one-pagers outside your org                                |
| PPTX (PowerPoint)      | Pitch decks or slides someone else needs to edit in PowerPoint or Google Slides                         |
| Send to Canva          | When you want to keep refining visually in Canva — opens as a fully editable Canva file                 |
| Standalone HTML        | Working prototype you can host, share via link, or load locally to test interactions                    |
| Download as .zip       | Backup, archive, or move the full project assets elsewhere                                              |
| Handoff to Claude Code | Send the design to Claude Code (local or web) so it can implement the prototype as real production code |

The Canva handoff

If you'd normally polish in Canva, the “Send to Canva” export keeps your design live. It opens as a fully editable Canva file with your layers intact — you can keep refining, share, and publish from there. Useful for marketers and founders who want to push past Claude Design’s editing controls.

The Claude Code handoff

This is the killer feature for product teams. When your prototype is approved, hand it off to Claude Code instead of writing a spec for an engineer. Claude Code reads the design and the design intent, then writes the actual frontend code. Two options:

- **Send to local coding agent** for engineers running Claude Code on their machine
- **Send to Claude Code Web** for cloud-based implementation

## SECTION 08

## Sharing and collaboration

**NOTE**

Sharing is organization-scoped — only people in your Anthropic organization can access shared projects.

### Three access levels

- **View only** teammates can see the design and read the chat history. Good for stakeholder reviews.
- **Comment** teammates can leave feedback on specific elements. Good for design reviews and iteration cycles.
- **Edit** teammates can modify the design and chat with Claude. Good for true collaboration.

### Sharing workflow

- Click Share in the project
- Pick the access level for the people you're sharing with
- Copy the link and send it
- Anyone in your org with the link can access at that level

**HEADS UP**

Real-time co-editing (multiple people working at the same time) is still basic in research preview. Treat sharing as asynchronous for now — one person works, hands off, the next person works.

## SECTION 09

# Ten use cases with starter prompts

Each case includes who it's for, when to use it, and a prompt you can adapt. Copy, modify, paste into chat.

1

## Founder pitch deck

**FOR** founders, startup teams

**WHEN** investor meetings, internal alignment, fundraising prep

### STARTER PROMPT

10-slide pitch deck for [my startup] in the [industry] space at [stage]. Slides: cover, problem, solution, market size, product (2-3 slides), traction, team, the ask. Audience: seed-stage VCs. Tone: confident, restrained, lots of breathing room. Use one big stat per slide where possible.

2

## Product landing page

**FOR** product marketers, founders, indie hackers

**WHEN** product launches, waitlist pages, campaign landing

### STARTER PROMPT

Landing page for [product name], a [one-line description] for [target user]. Sections: hero with headline + subhead + primary CTA, social proof bar (logos), 3 feature cards with icons, a 'how it works' section in 3 steps, pricing teaser, FAQ, footer CTA. Mobile-responsive. Modern SaaS feel, not corporate.

3

## Internal dashboard

**FOR** PMs, ops leads, internal tools builders

**WHEN** prototyping an admin view, internal tool concept, data review screen

### STARTER PROMPT

Internal dashboard for [team] tracking [what they care about]. Top row: 4 KPI tiles. Middle: a primary chart of [metric] over time. Bottom: a sortable table of recent items with status, owner, and timestamp. Add filters at the top: date range, status, owner. Functional over flashy.

4

## Mobile app onboarding flow

**FOR** app designers, PMs, founders pitching app concepts

**WHEN** designing first-time user experience, A/B testing onboarding ideas

### STARTER PROMPT

Mobile app onboarding flow with 4 screens for [app concept]. Screen 1: welcome + value prop. Screen 2: permissions ask (notifications, location). Screen 3: quick personalization (3 chips to tap). Screen 4: ready-to-start CTA. Progress indicator at the top throughout. Calming, friendly tone.

5

## Customer-feedback form

**FOR** researchers, PMs, customer-success teams

**WHEN** gathering structured input from users or prospects

### STARTER PROMPT

Feedback form for [purpose]. First question: a 5-point rating. Second: a multi-select for categories. Third: a conditional open-text question that only shows if rating is 3 or below. Fourth: optional contact info. Clean, single-column layout. Mobile-first.

6

## Feature wireframe for engineering handoff

**FOR** PMs, designers handing off to engineering

**WHEN** spec-ready visuals that engineers can build directly from

### STARTER PROMPT

Wireframe for a saved-filters feature in our [product type]. User can save the current filter set with a name, see a list of saved filters in a left sidebar, click one to apply, rename, or delete. Show: empty state, list of 3 saved filters, the active filter highlighted. Annotations on each interaction. Will hand off to Claude Code after.

7

## Marketing campaign one-pager

**FOR** marketers, founders, sales teams

**WHEN** sales enablement, partner briefings, internal kickoffs

### STARTER PROMPT

One-pager for [campaign name] targeting [audience]. Top: campaign name + one-line description. Middle: 3 columns covering positioning, key proof points, and target outcome. Bottom: CTA + contact info. On-brand. PDF-export ready.

8

## Conference talk slides

**FOR** speakers, founders, anyone presenting

**WHEN** talks, keynotes, demo presentations

### STARTER PROMPT

15-slide deck for a 20-minute conference talk on [topic]. Open with a hook story, then 3 main points each with a concrete example, then a recap, then a single closing slide. Bold visuals, minimal text per slide. Confident, conversational tone — not corporate.

9

## Interactive prototype for user testing

**FOR** researchers, designers, PMs

**WHEN** need a clickable prototype to put in front of users

STARTER PROMPT

Interactive prototype of [feature flow]. Make it clickable: button taps navigate to the next screen, the form submits and goes to a confirmation screen, the back arrow returns. Export-ready as standalone HTML so we can share via link with test participants.

10

Comparison page or feature matrix

FOR sales, marketing, product teams

WHEN competitive positioning, plan comparisons, feature transparency

STARTER PROMPT

Comparison table for our [3 pricing tiers / vs 2 competitors]. Rows: 10 features. Columns: the 3 options. Use clear checkmarks and X marks. Highlight the recommended option subtly. Clean, scannable. Bottom row: CTA for each column.

## SECTION 10

## Pro tips

**Start simple, then layer**

Don't try to specify everything in the first prompt. Get the core layout right, then add detail. Claude responds well to incremental requests.

**Reference your design system by name**

Instead of describing how a button should look, say "use the Primary Button component." Faster, more consistent, less explanation needed.

**Ask for alternatives before committing**

If you're not sure of the direction, ask for 2–3 options. Picking between options is faster than guessing whether one version is right.

**Use Claude as a design critic**

After generating, ask: "What would you change about this design?" or "What's the weakest part of this layout?" You'll get specific, actionable feedback.

**Mention responsiveness up front**

If it needs to work on mobile, tablet, and desktop, say so in the first prompt. Retrofitting is harder than starting that way.

**Be measurement-specific in feedback**

"Make it bigger" is fuzzy. "Increase the headline font size by about 25%" or "add 16px more padding around the card" is actionable. Numbers work.

**Use chat for explanation, comments for action**

If you want to understand a choice ("why is the CTA here?"), use chat. If you just want a fix, leave an inline comment on the canvas. Faster.

**Save a checkpoint before big swings**

Before trying a wildly different direction, say "save this version first." That way if you don't like the new direction, you can return easily.

SECTION 11

Troubleshooting

Claude Design is in research preview, which means some rough edges. Here’s what to do when things go sideways.

| PROBLEM                                    | WHAT TO DO                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Inline comments aren’t being picked up     | Paste the comment text directly into the chat instead. It’s a known glitch where comments occasionally vanish before Claude reads them.      |
| Save error in compact view                 | Switch to full view and retry the save. Compact view can trigger save bugs.                                                                  |
| Linking a big repo causes lag              | Don’t link entire monorepos. Link a specific subdirectory of the repo that’s actually relevant to what you’re designing.                     |
| “Chat upstream error”                      | Open a new chat tab within the same project. The project state is preserved; only the chat thread resets.                                    |
| Output doesn’t match brand                 | Confirm with your design lead that the design system is set up. If yes, mention specific component names in your prompt to force their use.  |
| Generic-looking output                     | Add more context: a reference screenshot, a tone description (“premium and restrained, not playful”), or a specific design you want to echo. |
| Claude went the wrong direction completely | Don’t keep nudging. Say: “Forget the current direction. Start over with: [new clear prompt].”                                                |

- A few realities to set expectations
- It’s a preview — features and behavior will change over time. Check the official docs when something looks different.
  - Best results come from the design system being well-configured. Messy source code or design files produce messy output.
  - Multiplayer collaboration is still basic. Treat it as async for now.

## SECTION 12

# Your first 30 minutes

If you've never opened Claude Design, here's the fastest path to feeling competent. Block 30 minutes, no interruptions.

Minute 0–5

## Open and orient

- Open Claude Design. Look at the two panels.
- Identify the chat box, the canvas area, the Export button (top right), and the Share button.
- Don't do anything else yet.

Minute 5–10

## Create your first project

- Click New Project. Use this prompt to see Claude work:

### EXAMPLE PROMPT

Landing page for a fictional productivity app called Calmly, aimed at busy professionals. Sections: hero with headline + CTA, 3 feature cards, a testimonial row, footer. Minimal, calming feel — soft colors, lots of whitespace.

Minute 10–15

## Try inline comments

- Click directly on the headline. Leave an inline comment: "Make this 30% larger and try a serif font." Watch the canvas update.
- Now click on a feature card and leave a comment changing one specific thing.

Minute 15–20

## Try chat for a structural change

- In the chat panel, type:

### EXAMPLE PROMPT

Show me 2 alternative layouts for this page — one with the feature cards in a vertical list and one with them in a 2x2 grid.

Minute 20–25

## Export

- Hit Export. Try PDF first to see what a static export looks like.
- Then try Standalone HTML to see what an interactive export gives you. Open the HTML in your browser.

Minute 25–30

## Hand off (optional)

- If you want to see the Canva handoff, export Send to Canva and explore.
- If you have Claude Code, try Handoff to Claude Code and see what implementation looks like.

### TIP

That's it. You're now functionally competent in Claude Design. Everything else is variation on this loop: *prompt* → *review* → *iterate* → *export*.

## Quick Reference Card

### THE PROMPT FORMULA

*[GOAL] for [AUDIENCE], with [KEY ELEMENTS],  
in a [STYLE/TONE] feel.*

### CHAT VS COMMENTS

**Comments** targeted, local changes (click the element, then comment)

**Chat** structural, broad, aesthetic, or explanatory

### THE 5-STEP LOOP

- Create project + add context
- Describe what you want
- Review the canvas
- Iterate via chat + comments
- Export or share

### WHEN STUCK

**Generic output** add context (screenshots, tone, component names)

**Wrong direction** reset with "Forget the current direction. Start over with: [clear prompt]"

**Comment ignored** paste it into chat instead

**Save error** switch to full view

**Chat error** open a new chat tab in the same project

### EXPORT OPTIONS

**PDF** static sharing

**PPTX** editable slides

**Send to Canva** keep refining in Canva

**Standalone HTML** interactive prototype

**Handoff to Claude Code** implement as real code

*Your turning point in the AI era.*

Claude Design · The Compact Playbook · menler.in